

## Chapter Twenty

### The Witness

The next morning, Nora woke to three messages.

One from Adam.

Did you sleep?

One from Maya.

Dad says apples are now under review as a fruit category. I blame you.

One from an unknown number.

This is Claire. Officer Holm asked if you would be willing to give a statement about what you heard that night. Only what you heard. Nothing else.

Nora sat up slowly.

Only what you heard.

Nothing else.

The sentence felt like a hand extended with a knife laid carefully beside it.

A boundary.

A request.

A warning.

Nora read it again.

Her heart began to beat faster, but not with pressure. With consequence.

Claire was asking her to enter the story again, but through the front door this time. No stolen memory. No private fear. No impossible knowledge. Only the ordinary facts a neighbor could give.

The smallest honest help.

Nora typed back:

Yes. I can do that.

Then she added:

Only what I heard.

Claire's reply came several minutes later.

Thank you.

No warmth.

No forgiveness.

Still, Nora held the phone against her chest for a moment before answering Adam.

Slept a little. Claire asked me to give a statement.

Adam replied quickly.

Do you want me there?

Nora stared at the question.

A week ago, she would have said yes before knowing whether she wanted comfort or witness or protection from herself. Now she considered it.

Did she want Adam there?

Yes.

Did she need him there?

Maybe.

Would his presence make her careful in a good way or dependent in the old way?

She did not know.

So she wrote the truth.

I want you there, but I don't want you to speak for me.

Adam answered:

I can stand beside you and say nothing.

Nora smiled faintly.

That may be your most romantic offer.

His reply came:

My silence is underrated.

Then Maya.

Nora sent her a short version.

Claire asked me for a statement. I'm going to give only what I heard.

Maya replied:

That sounds right. Hard, but right.

Then:

Also eat breakfast. Witnesses need toast.

Nora laughed.

She made toast.

Burned it.

Ate it anyway.

At noon, she met Officer Holm at the small police station near the square.

The building looked less dramatic than Nora expected. Pale walls. Automatic doors. A reception desk with scratched glass. A vending machine humming in the corner like it had been placed there specifically to make fear less cinematic.

Adam waited outside when she arrived.

He wore his dark coat and the face he used when he was trying not to look like a responsible ghost.

“You look haunted,” Nora said.

“I look supportive.”

“Hauntedly supportive.”

He held out a paper cup. “Tea.”

She took it. “Thank you.”

They stood outside the entrance for a moment.

Cars moved through the square. A cyclist shouted at a van. A woman dropped a glove and a stranger picked it up for her. Ordinary civic life continued around a building where people brought their worst nights and tried to turn them into paperwork.

Nora looked at Adam.

“I’m scared I’ll say too much.”

“Then pause before answering.”

“I’m scared I’ll say too little.”

“Then remember what Claire asked for.”

Nora nodded.

Only what you heard.

Nothing else.

Adam touched her sleeve. “Can I?”

She moved closer.

He hugged her.

No pressure came.

Just warmth, wool, tea, and the steady rhythm of his breathing.

When they entered, Officer Holm was waiting near reception. He greeted Nora politely and led her to a small interview room. Adam sat beside her, silent as promised.

The room contained a table, three chairs, a box of tissues, and a clock that ticked too loudly.

Officer Holm turned on a recorder after asking permission.

Nora gave her name.

Her address.

The date of the incident.

Her voice sounded calmer than she felt.

“Please describe what you heard,” Officer Holm said.

He did not say saw.

Nora was grateful.

She placed both hands in her lap.

“I was in my apartment. I heard voices through the wall. A woman’s voice. Claire’s. She said, ‘Please, just leave.’”

Officer Holm nodded. “Exact words?”

“Yes.”

“Then?”

“A male voice. I couldn’t make out every word, but he sounded angry. I heard him say, ‘Don’t make me the villain.’”

The sentence changed the room.

Officer Holm looked up.

Adam’s hand, resting on his own knee, tightened.

“You did not mention that in your first statement,” the officer said.

Nora swallowed.

“No.”

“Why not?”

Because I heard it from inside her body.

Because I was afraid saying it would expose the wrong truth.

Because I was still learning what belonged to me.

“I was shaken,” Nora said. “I didn’t trust myself to sort everything at the time.”

Officer Holm watched her.

It was not a lie.

Not fully.

Nora forced herself to stay still beneath his gaze.

“What else did you hear?”

“Claire cried out. Then there was a crash. A lamp, I think. Something glass breaking.”

“Did you hear a strike? A hit?”

Nora’s throat tightened.

Yes, from inside.

No, from my apartment.

She closed her eyes briefly.

“I can’t say that I heard a strike clearly,” she said. “I heard struggle. Movement. Then the crash.”

Officer Holm wrote something down.

Nora felt the old frustration rise.

The truth, whole and burning, sat just outside acceptable language.

He grabbed her arm.

Her cheek hurt.

The phone was under the coffee table.

She had been trapped between him and the door.

None of it could be said as hers.

None of it could become evidence through her mouth.

“Did you hear Ms. Levin ask him to leave more than once?”  
Officer Holm asked.

“Yes.”

“Did he leave?”

“Not until after we knocked and emergency services were called.”

“We?”

“My fiancé and other neighbors were in the hall.”

Officer Holm looked at Adam.

Adam spoke only when asked.

“I knocked,” he said. “Loudly. I told them police had been called.  
Another neighbor came out as well.”

His voice was steady.

Nora listened to it like a rope.

The statement lasted twenty-six minutes.

Nora gave what she could.

Not what she knew.

What she could.

When Officer Holm turned off the recorder, she felt emptied in a  
strange way. Not relieved. Not proud. Emptied.

As if she had carried a bucket of water to a fire and been told to pour only what had not been touched by smoke.

Outside the station, Adam asked, “How are you?”

Nora almost said fine.

He raised an eyebrow.

She sighed. “Angry.”

“Good.”

“Good?”

“Clear answer.”

She leaned against the brick wall.

“I said what I heard.”

“Yes.”

“But not what happened.”

Adam stood beside her. “You said what could help without violating her further.”

“That sounds like a sentence from a very ethical brochure.”

“It does.”

“I hate it.”

“I know.”

Nora looked across the square. People moved in and out of shops. A man laughed into his phone. A child cried because a pastry had broken in half. Someone somewhere was always suffering. Someone somewhere was always not.

“Do you think it will matter?” she asked.

Adam was quiet.

“I don’t know,” he said.



The answer hurt.

But at least it did not pretend.

Later that day, Claire texted.

Officer said your statement helps. I don't know how much. But it helps.

Nora read the message three times.

Then replied:

I'm glad.

She wanted to add more.

I'm sorry.

I believe you.

I wish truth had easier doors.

But Claire had asked for only what was needed.

So Nora left the message alone.

That evening, Maya came over with soup.

Not because Nora asked.

Because Maya had decided soup was "what morally decent people bring when the justice system enters the chat."

"The justice system did not enter the chat," Nora said, taking the container.

"It lurked."

Adam arrived half an hour later with bread.

"You two coordinated," Nora accused.

"We are capable of sharing logistical information without betraying you," Maya said, then froze.

The joke landed too close to the old wound.

For one second, the room held its breath.

Then Nora said, “Growth would be me admitting that was funny.”

Maya’s shoulders dropped.

Adam smiled.

“It was a little funny,” Nora admitted.

Maya pointed at her. “Safe enough and developing taste.”

They ate at Nora’s kitchen table.

Soup.

Bread.

Leftover cake from Maya’s dinner.

The conversation moved carefully at first, then more easily. Nora told them about the statement. Maya listened with her hands around her bowl. Adam filled in only the part where he had knocked.

When Nora finished, Maya said, “You sound disappointed.”

“I am.”

“In yourself?”

“In the world.”

Maya nodded slowly.

“That is fair.”

“I thought witnessing would feel like doing something.”

“It is doing something.”

“It feels like translating a scream into paperwork.”

Maya winced.

Adam looked down.

“That may be exactly what it is,” he said.

Nora stared at him.

He gave a tired half-smile. “Sorry. Too honest?”

“No. Unfortunately accurate.”

Maya pushed the bread toward Nora. “Eat. Existential outrage burns calories.”

Nora obeyed.

For a while, they sat with the unsolved thing among them.

Then Maya’s phone rang.

Lucia.

Maya answered quickly, as she always did now.

“Hi, Mom.”

Nora looked away.

Adam looked down at his bowl.

Maya listened.

Then her face changed.

Not fear.

Surprise.

“Wait, really?”

A pause.

“Tomorrow?”

Nora and Adam both looked at her.

Maya covered the phone and whispered, “They might discharge Dad tomorrow if the fever stays down.”

Nora’s chest lifted with relief.

Adam smiled.

Maya returned to the call. “No, Mom, that’s good. Yes. I know. I know home is work too.”

Her smile faded slightly.

Nora saw the shift.

Hospital fear was becoming home fear.

Different room.

Same illness.

Maya hung up after a few minutes and sat back.

“He might come home tomorrow,” she said.

“That’s good,” Nora said.

“It is.”

Maya did not sound convinced.

Adam asked, “What do you need?”

Maya’s eyes flicked to him.

Then Nora.

Then the table.

It was the question everyone had been practicing. Simple. Dangerous. Full of responsibility.

“I don’t know,” Maya said.

“Okay,” Nora said.

Maya looked relieved that no one rushed into the space with solutions.

Then, slowly, she said, “Maybe help setting up the living room? Mom wants him to rest downstairs for a few days because the bedroom is upstairs. We need to move furniture. Pick up prescriptions. Groceries.”

Adam nodded. “I can help after work.”

Nora said, “I can go in the morning if you want.”

Maya’s expression tightened.

Not much.

Enough.

Nora saw it.

Adam saw Nora see it.

The old story stood at the edge of the room, ready.

Maya does not trust you.

Maya wants Adam.

Maya thinks you are unsafe.

Nora breathed once.

The panic-dog barked.

She did not hand it a weapon.

“Maya,” Nora said, “I’m hearing a story. I’m going to say it before it grows teeth.”

Maya went still.

Adam looked at her carefully.

Nora continued, “When I offered to help and your face changed, part of me thought you don’t want me there because you still don’t trust me.”

Maya's eyes softened with immediate pain.

"And maybe that's true," Nora added quickly. "Or partly true. But I'm asking instead of deciding."

The room was very quiet.

Then Maya placed her spoon down.

"My face changed because I imagined you alone in my parents' house with my mother while everything is stressful," she said. "And yes, part of me worried. Not because I don't want you. Because my mother is scared and my father will be difficult and there will be medical instructions and family things everywhere."

Nora nodded slowly.

"That makes sense."

Maya's mouth trembled.

"But I do want you," she said. "Just not alone in the middle of it."

Nora absorbed that.

It hurt.

Less than the story would have.

More honestly.

"So maybe I come when you're there," Nora said.

Maya nodded. "Yes. Please."

Nora smiled faintly. "Look at us. Conversing before tragedy."

Adam lifted his bowl. "A radical innovation."

Maya sniffed. "Disgusting but effective."

The next day, Tomas came home.

Home, Nora discovered, did not look like relief from close up.

It looked like chairs pushed against walls, folded blankets, pharmacy bags, Lucia wiping the same counter three times, Maya reading discharge papers with a highlighter, Tomas sitting in an armchair near the window pretending he was not exhausted by the journey from hospital bed to car to house.

Nora arrived with Maya.

Adam came later after work.

That helped.

Nora did not enter the house as rescuer.

She entered as invited help.

Lucia kissed her cheek and immediately handed her a list.

“You are good with lists?” Lucia asked.

Nora glanced at Maya.

Maya smiled. “She is dangerous with lists.”

Lucia looked concerned.

Nora laughed. “I can be medium with lists.”

“Medium is good,” Lucia said. “Too good is stressful.”

Tomas, from the chair, lifted one hand. “Everything is stressful. Bring apples.”

“You are not eating another apple until dinner,” Lucia said.

“This house has become a prison.”

“You were in a hospital yesterday.”

“Exactly. I know prison.”

Maya rolled her eyes so hard Nora feared injury.

For two hours, Nora did small things.

Small, acceptable things.

She moved books from the side table so medication could sit there. She washed mugs. She folded blankets. She wrote times on a notepad because Lucia asked her to, then gave the notepad back instead of keeping control of it.

When Maya disappeared into the kitchen and stayed too long, Nora did not follow immediately.

She waited.

Then Maya called, “Nora?”

Nora went.

Maya stood by the sink, crying silently.

No pressure came.

No jump.

Only invitation.

Nora stopped in the doorway.

“Closer?” she asked.

Maya nodded.

Nora crossed the kitchen.

Maya leaned into her.

“I thought home would feel better,” Maya whispered.

Nora held her carefully.

“What does it feel like?”

“Like the hospital came with us.”

Nora closed her eyes.

That was exactly it.

The machines were gone, the nurses gone, the antiseptic smell replaced by cumin and laundry soap and old wood. But fear had



moved into the living room and sat beside Tomas like another relative.

“I’m sorry,” Nora said.

Maya shook her head against her shoulder.

“No fixing?”

“No fixing.”

“Good.”

They stood there until Lucia called from the living room, “Maya? Where are the blue pills?”

Maya wiped her face quickly.

Nora handed her a towel.

Maya took it.

“Blue pills,” Maya said.

“Very specific.”

“Deeply.”

They returned to the living room.

Adam arrived at six with groceries and the expression of a man prepared to be useful but attempting not to radiate it.

Tomas saw him and pointed.

“You. Tall man. Move that lamp.”

Adam looked at Maya.

Maya shrugged. “You heard the patient.”

Adam moved the lamp.

“Too far,” Tomas said.

Adam moved it back slightly.

“Too near.”

Adam closed his eyes briefly.

Nora covered a laugh.

Maya whispered, “Welcome to our home care plan.”

By evening, everyone was exhausted.

Lucia insisted they all eat. Tomas complained about the soup, then finished it. Adam repaired a loose cabinet handle because Lucia mentioned it in passing and then looked guilty when everyone stared at him.

“What?” he said.

Maya pointed with her spoon. “Checklist face.”

“It was loose.”

“Nobody asked you to be a hardware saint.”

Lucia looked at the cabinet, delighted. “No, this is good. Let him.”

Adam sat down, chastened but secretly pleased.

Nora laughed.

For one strange hour, illness did not vanish, but life made room around it.

Then the phone rang.

Tomas’s phone.

Everyone paused.

Tomas looked at the screen.

His face changed in a way Nora could not read.

He did not answer.

The ringing stopped.

Lucia looked at him. “Who was it?”

“No one.”

Maya’s body went still.

Nora felt the room tighten.

No one.

The oldest lie in every family.

Tomas set the phone facedown on the side table.

Maya asked, “Dad?”

“I said no one.”

His voice was sharper than before.

Lucia’s face went pale.

Adam looked at Nora.

Nora looked away.

Do not search.

The phone buzzed again.

A message this time.

Tomas did not reach for it.

The pressure touched Nora’s eyes.

Soft.

Familiar.

Dangerous.

Not from Lucia.

Not from Maya.

From Tomas.

A door she had never entered.

A fear wrapped in pride and morphine and old secrets.

Nora gripped the edge of her chair.

Maya noticed immediately.

“Nora?”

Tomas looked at her.

His eyes narrowed.

He knew.

Somehow, impossibly, he knew when the room shifted toward him.

“Do not,” he said.

Nora swallowed.

“I’m not.”

The phone buzzed again.

Tomas flinched.

Lucia saw it.

“Tomas,” she said quietly. “Who is calling?”

He looked away.

The pressure grew.

Nora could feel the shape of something old.

Not illness.

Not fear of death.

Shame.

A hidden room inside Tomas Santos.

The air seemed to thicken.

Maya stood. “Dad, what is going on?”

“Nothing.”

Nora pressed her nails into her palm.

Stay.

Stay.

Stay.

The phone buzzed a third time.

Tomas grabbed it and shoved it under the blanket.

Too late.

Maya had seen the name.

Her face went blank.

Nora could not see the screen.

She did not need to.

Maya whispered, “Isabel?”

Lucia sat down slowly.

The name entered the room like a ghost invited by no one.

Tomas closed his eyes.

Maya looked from her father to her mother.

“Who is Isabel?”

No one answered.

The pressure became a roar.

Nora stood abruptly.

Adam stood too.

“Nora,” he said.

“I need air.”

She moved toward the hallway.

Not because she wanted to leave.

Because she wanted desperately to stay and know.

The door inside her had begun to open.

Tomas’s shame.

Lucia’s fear.

Maya’s confusion.

The story was forming in pieces already.

Isabel.

A hidden woman.

A call ignored.

A name that made Lucia pale.

A secret older than cancer.

Nora reached the hallway and braced both hands against the wall.

Behind her, Maya said again, “Who is Isabel?”

Tomas answered at last.

But his voice was too low for Nora to hear.

The pressure surged.

Nora squeezed her eyes shut.

Do not use what they did not give.

But Maya's voice cracked.

"What do you mean, my sister?"

The words struck Nora like a door blown open.

Her eyes snapped open.

Maya had a sister.

The thought arrived before the jump.

Maya had a sister.

Nora, who had built her life around a chosen sister because blood had not given her one, stood in the hallway of Maya's family home and felt the room behind her become something unrecognizable.

A sister.

Hidden.

Named Isabel.

The pressure hit hard enough to buckle her knees.

Adam caught her before she fell.

"Stay," he said urgently.

Nora gripped his arms.

Inside the living room, Maya said, "You hid a person from me?"

Lucia began to cry.

Tomas said something.

Maya's voice rose.

"No. No, don't say you were protecting me."

Nora shook violently.

Fear found its favorite shape.

Exclusion.

Replacement.

A sister Maya had not known.

A sister whose existence had been kept secret.

A new version of the old wound.

Adam held her firmly.

“Nora, look at me.”

She tried.

The hallway blurred.

“I can’t—”

“You can.”

“She has a sister.”

“I know.”

“No, you don’t understand.”

“I do.”

“No.” Nora’s voice broke. “I’m not supposed to be in this room.”

“Then don’t enter it.”

The words cut through the pressure.

Do not enter it.

The room behind her was full of pain, secrets, blood, betrayal, history.

And none of it was hers unless Maya brought it to her.

Nora sobbed once.



The pressure trembled.

Inside, Maya was crying now. Not loudly. Worse than that. Quietly, as if the sound had been punched out of her.

Nora's body leaned toward the living room.

Adam held her.

Not restraining.

Anchoring.

"You are here," he said. "You are in the hallway. You are with me. Maya is in her family's room. Let her have her own shock."

The pressure screamed.

Then faded.

Not all at once.

In waves.

Nora slid down the wall until she was sitting on the floor.

Adam crouched beside her.

From the living room came broken voices.

Maya asking questions.

Lucia crying.

Tomas answering in fragments.

Isabel.

Older.

Before Lucia.

No, not before.

Complicated.

A child sent away.

Letters.

Silence.

Shame.

Nora put her hands over her ears.

Adam sat beside her and did not move.

After a few minutes, Maya appeared in the hallway.

Her face was white.

Her eyes went to Nora on the floor.

Then to Adam.

Then back to Nora.

“You knew?” Maya whispered.

The question stopped Nora’s heart.

“No.”

Maya stared at her.

Nora shook her head. “No. I swear. I didn’t know.”

Maya’s face twisted.

“Don’t swear.”

Nora flinched.

Maya looked like she might fall apart or catch fire.

Maybe both.

“I have a sister,” she said.

The sentence was not information.

It was an injury.

Nora stood slowly, using the wall.

Adam rose beside her.

Maya looked at Nora with a gaze so full of pain it was almost unbearable.

“A real one,” Maya said.

The words entered Nora before Maya could stop them.

Nora went still.

Adam’s face changed.

Maya heard herself.

Horror crossed her expression.

“Nora—”

But the damage had already arrived.

A real one.

Not chosen.

Not made through late-night crying and pastry bags and university lectures and old church gardens.

A real one.

Blood.

Hidden.

Original.

Nora felt something inside her step backward from Maya.

The old wound opened with terrifying precision.

Maya reached for her. “I didn’t mean—”

“Yes,” Nora said.

Her voice sounded strange.

Far away.

“You did.”

Maya began to cry.

“I’m sorry.”

“I know.”

But this time, the words were not enough.

Nora looked toward the living room.

Lucia sat with her face in her hands. Tomas stared at the floor, ruined by a secret that had outlived his courage. A phone lay on the table, screen dark now, but still somehow the brightest thing in the room.

Isabel.

A sister.

A secret.

A betrayal that was not romantic at all, but old, familial, structural. The kind that rearranged a person’s history without asking permission.

Nora should have felt only compassion for Maya.

She did feel compassion.

But beneath it, uglier, older, faster:

Where does that leave me?

The shame of the thought nearly made her sick.

Maya had just been wounded.

Nora’s fear had immediately checked its own place in the story.

Adam's hand touched her back lightly.

She stepped away from it.

"I should go," Nora said.

Maya's face crumpled. "No. Please."

"You need your family."

"You are my family."

The words came too late.

Or Nora was too hurt to receive them.

"I'm not the room you need right now," Nora said.

Maya shook her head. "Don't do this."

"I'm trying not to do anything."

"You're leaving."

"Because I don't trust myself to stay without making this about me."

The honesty hurt everyone.

Maya looked at her as if she had slapped her.

Adam said softly, "Nora."

She turned to him. "Can you take me home?"

Maya looked between them.

The old triangle returned instantly.

Cruel.

Uninvited.

Adam hesitated.

Only a second.

But everyone saw it.

Maya whispered, “Go.”

“Maya—” Adam began.

“No.” Maya wiped her face with the back of her hand. “She’s right. I need my family. Apparently I have more of it than I knew.”

The bitterness in her voice was new.

Sharp enough to cut the air.

Nora stepped toward the door.

At the threshold, she stopped.

Looked back.

Maya stood in the hallway, shaking, wounded, furious, newly sistered and newly alone.

Nora wanted to return.

Wanted to hold her.

Wanted to demand reassurance.

Wanted to ask whether chosen still counted when blood arrived late.

Instead, she said, “I’m sorry.”

Maya’s face hardened around tears.

“Me too.”

Nora left.

Adam followed.

Outside, the night was cold.

For a while, neither spoke.

The drive home was almost silent.

Nora sat with her hands clenched in her lap, watching the city pass in pieces through the window.

The version outside the glass was simple.

A woman and her fiancé leaving another woman's family crisis.

The truth inside the car was not simple at all.

Adam finally said, "She didn't mean it."

Nora laughed once.

It came out brittle.

"Yes, she did."

"She was in shock."

"People in shock still mean things."

"They also say things badly."

Nora looked at him. "Do you think I don't know that?"

Adam's jaw tightened.

She turned back to the window.

A real one.

The words kept repeating.

Nora hated herself for caring.

Hated Maya for saying it.

Hated Tomas for hiding Isabel.

Hated Lucia for knowing.

Hated Adam for being calm.

Hated that none of these hatreds had a clean place to land.

At her apartment, Adam parked but did not turn off the engine immediately.

“You shouldn’t be alone tonight,” he said.

There it was.

Concern.

Doubt.

Maybe both.

Nora unbuckled her seatbelt.

“I need to be.”

“Nora.”

“No.”

She opened the car door.

Adam turned off the engine and followed her upstairs anyway.

She did not tell him not to.

At her door, she took out her keys.

Her hands shook.

Adam stood beside her.

“Please talk to me,” he said.

“I can’t.”

“Then let me sit with you.”

“If you sit with me, I’ll say something cruel.”

“I can survive cruel.”

“I don’t want you to have to.”

He went quiet.



Nora unlocked the door.

Before entering, she looked at him.

“Maya has a sister,” she said.

Adam’s expression softened painfully. “Yes.”

“And I am horrible because the part of that that hurts most is not the betrayal done to her, but the place I’m afraid I just lost.”

“You’re not horrible.”

“I am.”

“No,” Adam said. “You are wounded in the exact shape this news hit.”

The tenderness almost broke her.

She could not bear it.

“Go home,” she whispered.

Adam closed his eyes.

When he opened them, he looked exhausted.

“Text me if pressure comes.”

Nora nodded.

“Promise?”

She almost swore.

Maya’s voice cut through memory.

Don’t swear.

Nora swallowed.

“I’ll try.”

Adam accepted the weaker answer because it was the truer one.

Then he left.

Nora entered her apartment alone.

The quiet was immediate.

Heavy.

She locked the door, walked to the kitchen, and opened  
BORDERS.

The document waited with all its careful lessons.

Do not confuse pain with permission.

Do not confuse closeness with ownership.

I cannot be justice. I can be a witness.

She stared at the words until they became insulting.

Then she typed:

What happens when someone else's truth takes your place?

She looked at the sentence.

Then deleted it.

Then typed:

A real one.

The pressure came before she could delete that.

Violent.

Instant.

Not from Maya.

Not from Adam.

Not from Tomas or Lucia.

From somewhere older.

A girl.

A girl with Maya's eyes and an unfamiliar mouth.

A girl reading letters she was never meant to receive.

Isabel.

Nora stood so quickly the chair fell backward.

“No.”

The pressure slammed into her.

The apartment split apart.

And for the first time in days, Nora did not hold the door closed.

She fell through it reaching.